MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 2: Critiquing Shakespearean Drama

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

A critique explains how a play makes meaning through language, performance, structure, and context rather than merely retelling events.

Start with a picture

A friend tells you what happened in a film. A critic asks why a close-up mattered, how the music changed the scene, and whose point of view guided the audience. Drama criticism needs the same move from event to method and effect.

1. Start with a question and a claim

A topic is “disguise in Twelfth Night.” A claim is “Viola’s disguise gives her opportunities while making honest declarations of love difficult.” The claim is arguable and can be tested through scenes.

Do not begin with an enormous statement about all humanity if the question asks about one speech.

2. Choose evidence at the right scale

A phrase can support a language argument. A scene can support an argument about interaction. A pattern across the whole play can support a structural argument. Exact quotations should come from the assigned text, not a remembered paraphrase presented in quotation marks.

Identify the speaker, situation, and audience within the play. The meaning of an instruction or confession changes according to who hears it.

3. Analyse dramatic language

Attend to imagery, punning, repetition, rhythm, prose versus verse, and changes in address. Explain an effect. For instance, repetition may suggest persuasion, anxiety, mockery, or ritual, depending on the scene.

Calling a line “powerful” is not enough; show how the wording produces the effect you describe.

4. Read the play as something performed

An open platform, entrances, upper spaces, visible actors, and a physically present audience shape what is possible. Spoken setting can replace a painted location. An aside can make spectators share information with one character against another.

The physical stage also offers choices to directors. A text may permit several defensible performances, not one inevitable arrangement of gesture and tone.

5. Five-act movement

A useful broad pattern is exposition, developing conflict, crisis or turning pressure, consequences, and resolution or catastrophe. Actual plays do not mechanically reproduce a school diagram. Explain how a particular scene changes what becomes possible afterwards.

6. Order, genre, and endings

Tragedy can expose the breakdown of a political or family arrangement. Comedy often moves towards a new social settlement. Romance can explore recovery after loss. History dramatises claims about national or royal legitimacy.

An ending may restore one order while excluding another possibility. Ask who benefits. Hamlet’s deaths and Fortinbras’s arrival differ from the twin recognition and marriage arrangements of Twelfth Night. Antony and Cleopatra joins historical power with tragic self-presentation, showing why categories overlap.

7. A reliable paragraph pattern

Point → evidence → analysis → link. State one claim, choose a detail, explain its technique and effect, then connect it to the question. Context should help interpretation at the point where it is useful.

Quick check

1. What distinguishes critique from plot summary? **Explanation of method, effect, and significance.**
2. Must every five-act play fit one rigid diagram? **No.**
3. Does a restored political order settle every moral problem? **Not necessarily.**

Build an exam answer

1. Form an arguable claim.
2. Choose a scene and relevant verbal detail.
3. Explain staging and knowledge distribution.
4. Connect the scene to structure and context.
5. Evaluate the ending or an alternative interpretation.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not quote without explaining, list devices without effects, or let a large historical introduction displace the actual question.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Demonstrate a method for writing a critical answer on Shakespearean drama.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

A critical answer begins by converting a broad topic into a focused proposition. The claim that Twelfth Night contains disguise only identifies a device. The claim that disguise makes desire depend on unstable outward signs begins an argument. It can be supported by Olivia’s response to Cesario and by Viola’s inability to disclose her situation freely.

Evidence needs analysis at both linguistic and theatrical levels. Spectators know that Cesario is Viola, so the words spoken in courtship carry meanings unavailable to some characters. Dramatic irony gives the exchange a comic energy while also exposing emotional vulnerability. This explanation connects the device with an effect instead of assuming that the device explains itself.

Structure and context can then deepen the argument. The separation produced by the shipwreck makes disguise useful; the arrival and recognition of Sebastian make its central confusion resolvable. Yet the treatment of Malvolio reminds readers that the movement towards marriage does not heal every wrong. Comedy therefore describes the principal trajectory while leaving room for critical qualification.

The same method can be applied to a tragedy. A Hamlet paragraph might connect a soliloquy’s changing argument with the pressure of uncertain knowledge, rather than simply describing the prince as indecisive. In either case, context, genre, and critical vocabulary should serve a particular reading. The conclusion should return to the question with a judgement earned through the details already analysed.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. What are the different steps involved in formulating a critique of Shakespearean plays?
2. Describe the physical features of the Elizabethan stage.
3. How did Elizabethan stage features influence Shakespearean plays?

4. Briefly explain the five-act structure of the Shakespearean play.
5. How is the concept of order employed in Shakespearean drama?
6. Which are the four types of Shakespearean plays?
7. Consider Twelfth Night as a Shakespearean comedy.
8. Examine Hamlet as a Shakespearean tragedy.
9. Detail the intermixing of different dramatic types in Antony and Cleopatra.